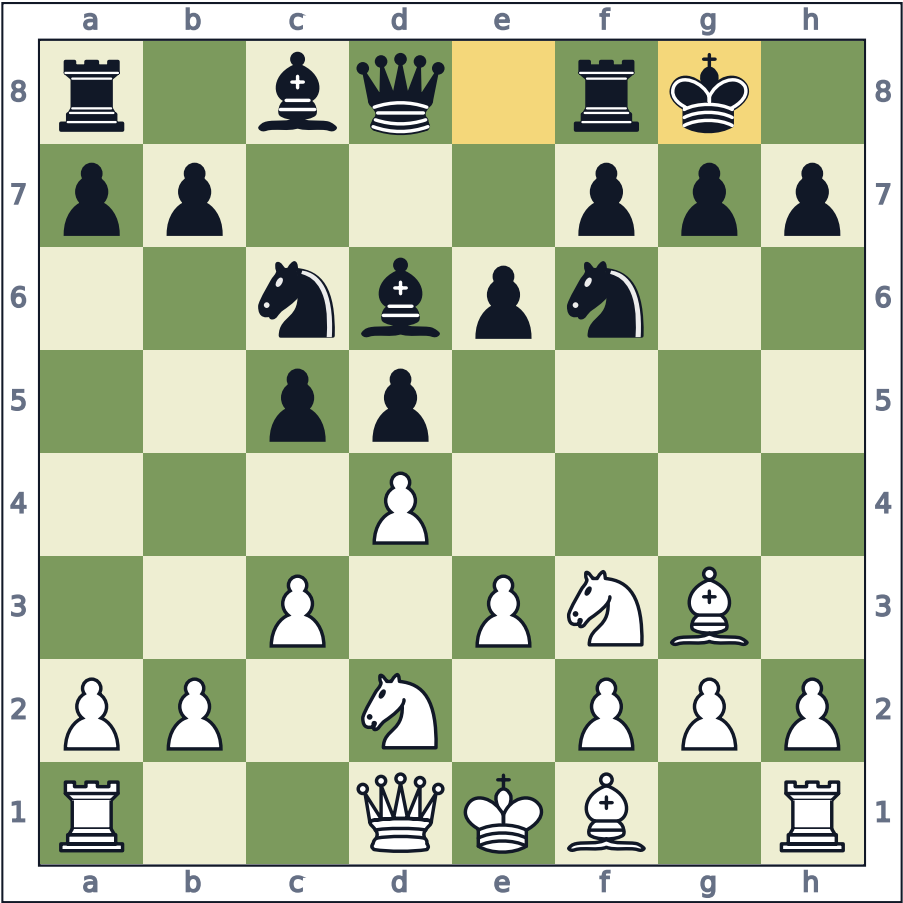


London System

A ground-up visual course for practical play



Core route position - gold marks the last move

WHITE FOCUS

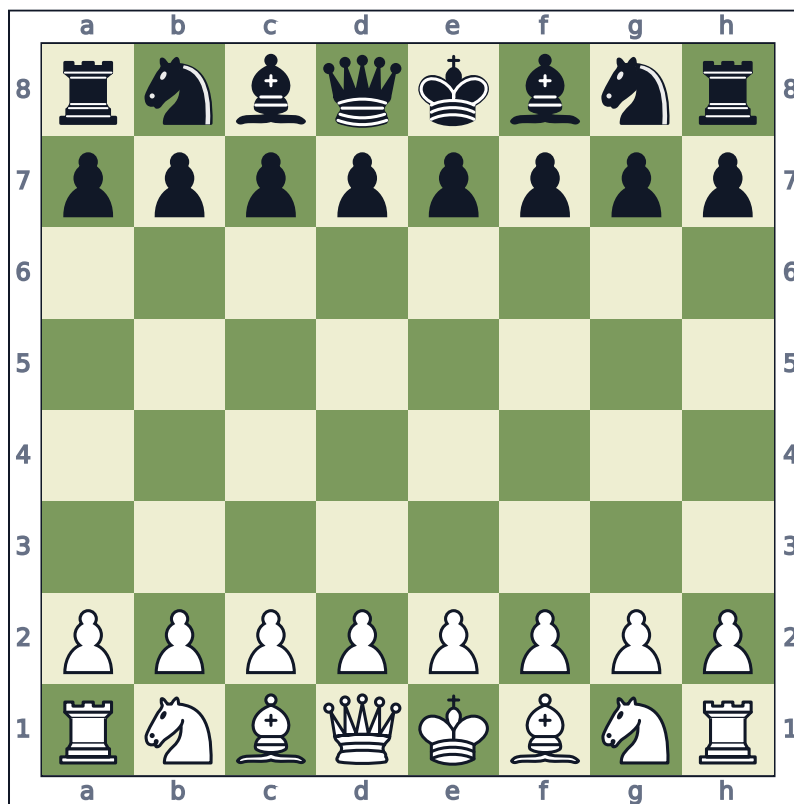
OPENING IDENTITY

White builds a dependable development scheme with the bishop outside the pawn chain.

ORIENTATION

Ground zero: read the board and the moves

White starts from ranks 1-2; Black starts from ranks 7-8. Files run a through h. Each lesson highlights the last move in gold so your eyes connect notation to the board.



Starting position - White to move

HOW ALGEBRAIC NOTATION WORKS

Nf3 means a knight moves to f3. B means bishop, R rook, Q queen, K king; pawns use only the destination square. An x means capture, + means check, and O-O means kingside castling.

YOUR FIRST ANCHOR

Say the first moves aloud, then point to every destination square:

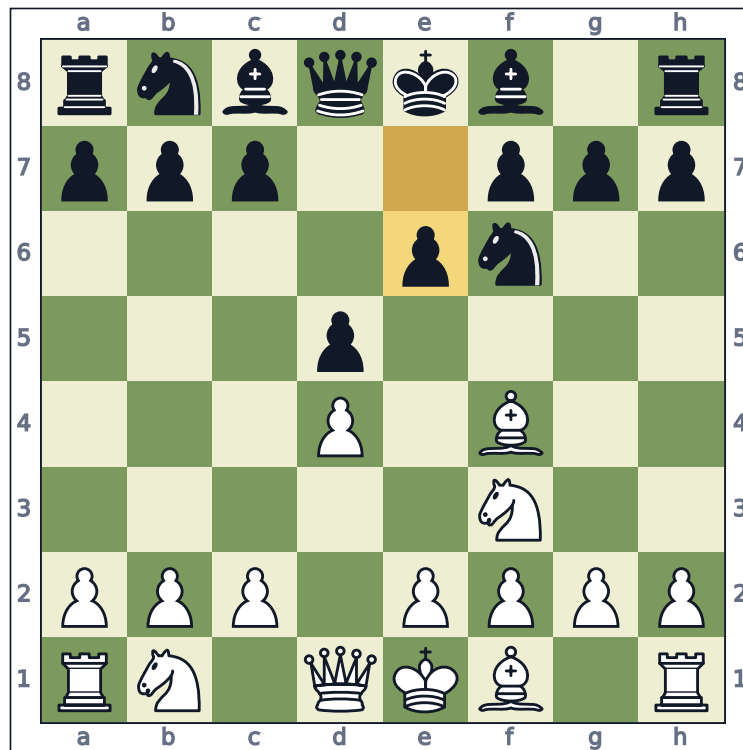
1. d4 d5 2. Nf3 Nf6 3. Bf4 e6

Course promise: A system is a map, not autopilot.

MOVES 1-3

Lesson 1: the first conversation

1. d4 d5 2. Nf3 Nf6 3. Bf4 e6



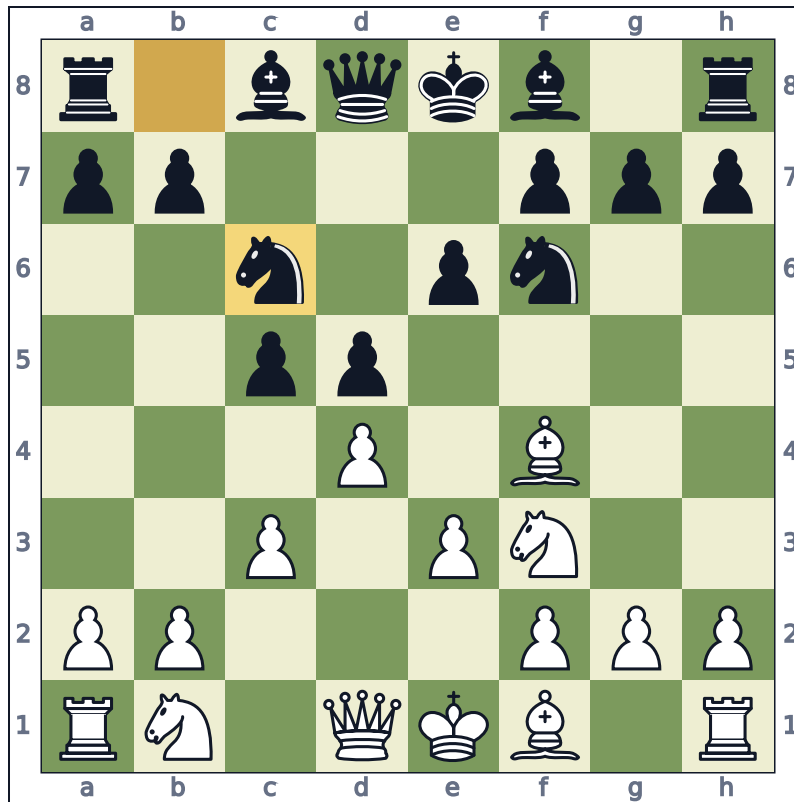
After 3. Bf4 e6

- 1. d4 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.
- 1... d5 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.
- 2. Nf3 - Develops a knight toward the center and increases control of key central squares.
- 2... Nf6 - Develops a knight toward the center and increases control of key central squares.
- 3. Bf4 - Develops on an active diagonal, often adding a pin or long-range pressure.
- 3... e6 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.

DEVELOPMENT

Lesson 2: build the core position

1. d4 d5 2. Nf3 Nf6 3. Bf4 e6 4. e3 c5 5. c3 Nc6



White to move

WHAT THE PIECES ARE BUILDING

White builds a dependable development scheme with the bishop outside the pawn chain.

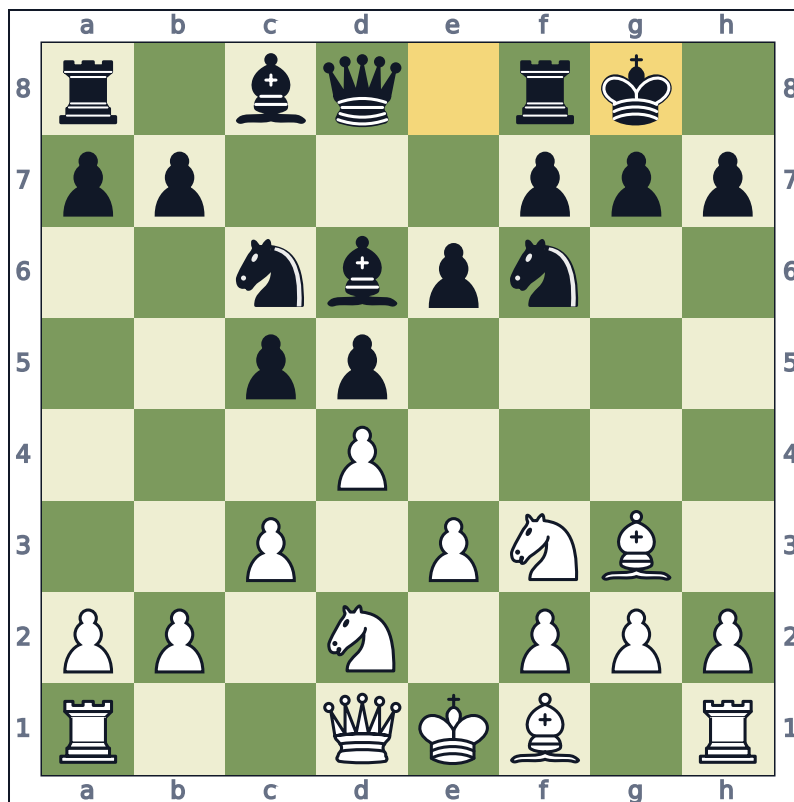
BEGINNER CHECKPOINT

Before copying the next move, ask: Is my king safe? Which piece is still at home? What changed in the center? Which pawn break is each side preparing?

CORE LINE

Lesson 3: complete the main route

1. d4 d5 2. Nf3 Nf6 3. Bf4 e6 4. e3 c5 5. c3 Nc6 6. Nbd2 Bd6 7. Bg3 O-O



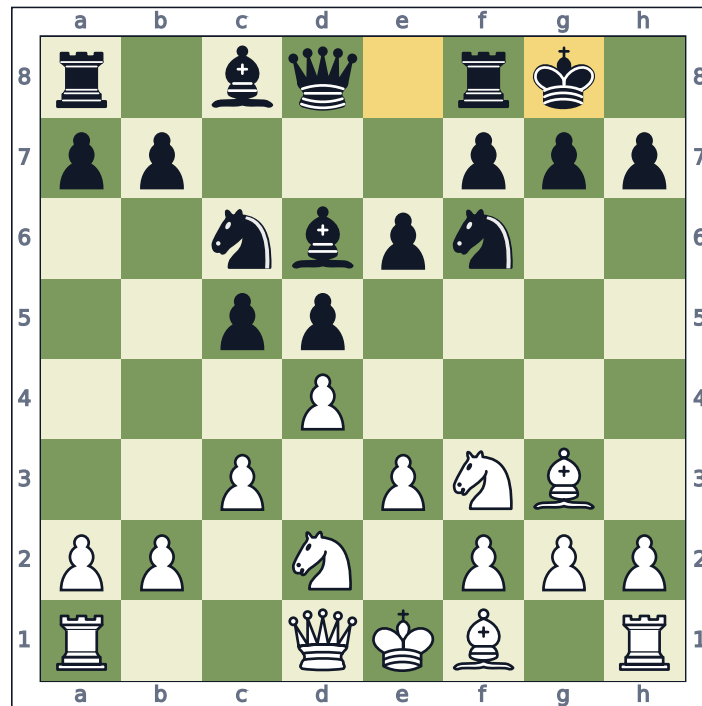
Core position - now plans matter more than memorized moves

DO NOT MEMORIZE BLINDLY

The route is a model, not a forced script. Its job is to teach this relationship: White builds a dependable development scheme with the bishop outside the pawn chain. If the opponent deviates, preserve the same priorities until a concrete tactic changes them.

UNDERSTANDING

The position map: plans for both sides



Read plans from the pawn structure, not from the opening name

WHITE'S PLAN

Complete the triangle, castle, and choose e4 or queenside play based on Black's center.

BLACK'S PLAN

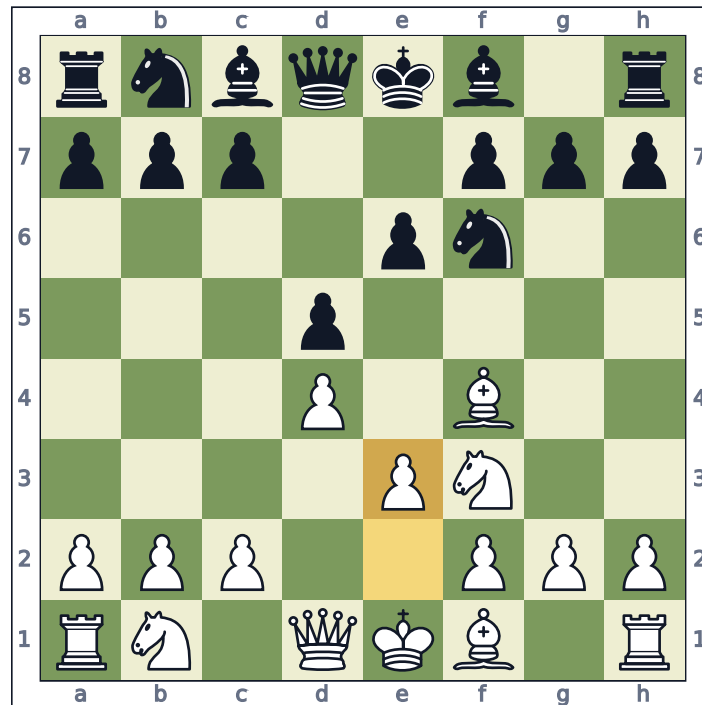
Challenge d4 early, develop actively, and avoid treating the setup as untouchable.

THE LEVER TO REMEMBER

White's e4 is the main ambition; Black's ...c5 immediately questions d4.

CALCULATION

Tactical literacy: what can suddenly change



Pause here - Black to move

THEME

The h2-b8 diagonal and Ne5 can create kingside pressure once development is complete.

COMMON BEGINNER ERROR

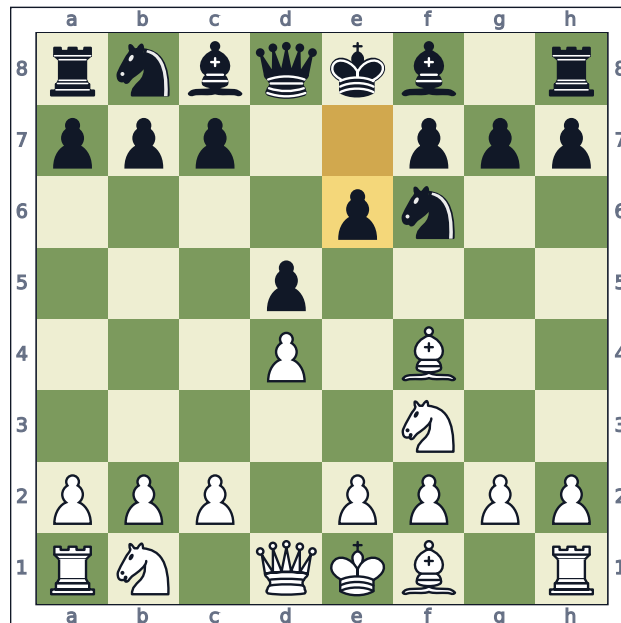
Playing the same diagram regardless of Black's threats.

THREE-SECOND SAFETY SCAN

1. Checks against both kings. 2. Captures in the center. 3. Threats against loose or pinned pieces.

ADAPTATION

Decision tree: when the opponent leaves the route



A branch point - principles are your map

1. If the center stays fluid

Finish development and keep the opening identity in view: White builds a dependable development scheme with the bishop outside the pawn chain.

2. If the center closes

Use the pawn-chain direction. Attack the base before making wing moves that cannot be supported.

3. If the center opens

Prioritize king safety, active pieces, and checks or captures before slow pawn moves.

4. If nothing is forced

Return to the planned lever: White's e4 is the main ambition; Black's ...c5 immediately questions d4.

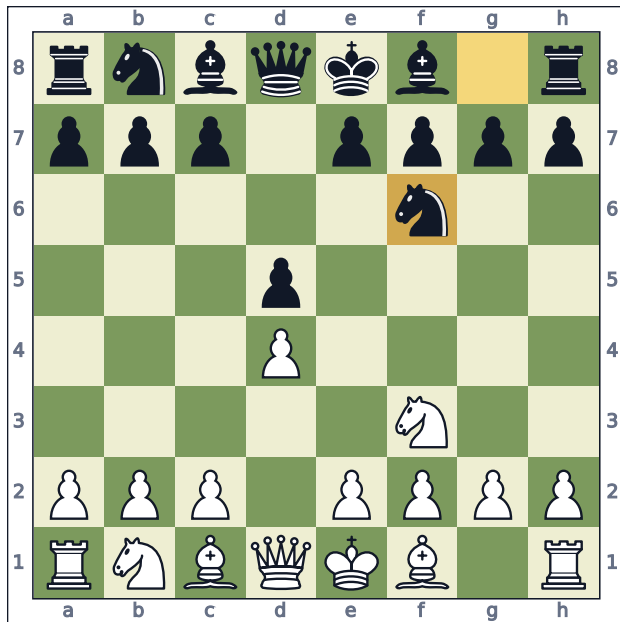
MEMORY SENTENCE

A system is a map, not autopilot.

ACTIVE RECALL

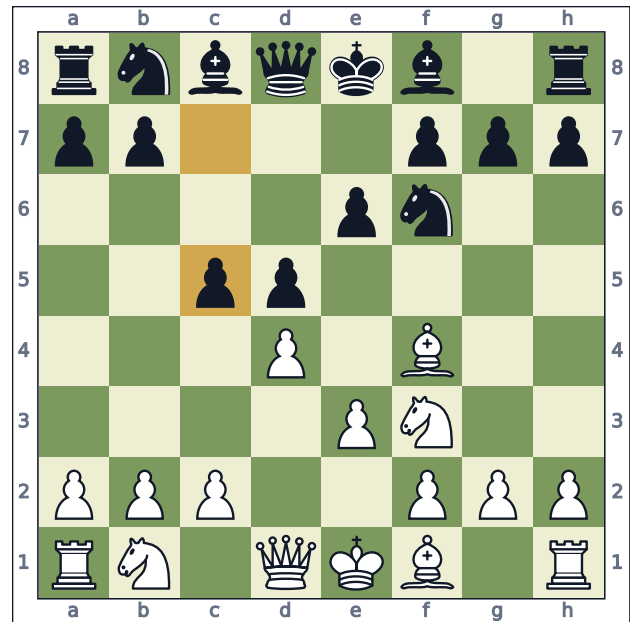
Recall test: answer before you turn the page

POSITION A



White to move

POSITION B



White to move

- A1. What is the next route move for White?
- A2. What opening problem does that move solve?
- B1. What is the next route move for White?
- B2. Name one plan for White and one plan for Black.
- C. State the thematic pawn break without looking back.

SCORING

5/5: replay from memory. 3-4/5: review Lessons 3 and 6. 0-2/5: return to Lesson 1 and rebuild the route slowly.

RETENTION

Answer key and a 14-day practice loop

POSITION A

Next route move: Bf4. Explain it using development, center, king safety, or a direct tactical need.

POSITION B

Next route move: c3. Then compare the position with the final core board.

PLAN AND BREAK ANSWERS

White: Complete the triangle, castle, and choose e4 or queenside play based on Black's center. Black: Challenge d4 early, develop actively, and avoid treating the setup as untouchable. Lever: White's e4 is the main ambition; Black's ...c5 immediately questions d4.

14-DAY LOOP

- Days 1-2: replay the first three moves from both sides and name each move's job.
- Days 3-4: build the core position from memory; correct the first error, then restart.
- Days 5-6: say White's plan, Black's plan, and the pawn break without a board.
- Day 7: take the recall test. Record the score; do not count lucky guesses.
- Days 8-10: play three slow practice games, starting from the core position if possible.
- Days 11-13: review only mistakes and deviations that actually occurred in your games.
- Day 14: retake the test and write a one-sentence opening rule in your own words.